

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Significance & Decline of Mauryan Rule - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Significance & Decline of Mauryan Rule REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION - BACKCORE FIRST	
01 SIGNIFICANCE MATRIX: SCALE, COMMUNICATION, POLITICAL ETHICS AND Technically, Significance matrix: scale, communication, political ethics	02 POLITICAL INTEGRATION AND THE REGIONAL LIMITS OF THE FIRST VIRTUALLY The Mauryan created a new scale of political integration through a
03 ADMINISTRATIVE PRECEDENT VERSUS THE DIFFERENTIATED-CONTROL DEBATE Mauryan rule changed the vocabulary and evolution of governance.	04 COMMUNICATION ROUTES, TRANSPORT AND INSCRIPTIONAL GOVERNANCE Integration is evidence of governance, not textual completion.
05 ECONOMY, FISCAL AMBITION AND THE SPREAD OF MATERIAL-STATE CAPACITY Rumormongers to change focus evidence than an uncombed state list.	06 INSCRIPTIONAL PUBLIC COMMUNICATION, SCRIPTS AND LANGUAGES Ashokan public epigraphy is a foundational Mauryan legacy.
07 DHAMMA, SOCIAL PLURALITY AND THE POLITICAL ETHICS OF KINGSHIP Dhamma and Buddhism overlap but are not identical.	08 ART, ARCHITECTURE, CRAFT KNOWLEDGE AND CULTURAL LEGACY Mauryan/PYG use for every monument write pattern/inscription.
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Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Hard MCQ 01 - Empire, dynasty and legacy

Question: Which formulation most accurately distinguishes the three historical objects in Topic 15?

- (a) Ashoka's death, the later loss of imperial integration, and the afterlife of Mauryan practices are related but differently dated processes.
- (b) Legacy means every Mauryan office survived unchanged under the Shungas.
- (c) The dynasty ended first, followed by Ashoka's death and then imperial weakening.
- (d) The empire, dynasty and legacy all ended in 232 BCE.

Answer: A - Ashoka's death, the later loss of imperial integration, and the afterlife of Mauryan practices are related but differently dated processes. Explanation: Ashoka died in 232 BCE, while the dynasty conventionally ended c. 187/185 BCE; imperial integration weakened unevenly and selected practices and symbols outlived both. The distinction prevents political decline from becoming a claim of civilisational disappearance.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 961-965; repository Master Chronology.

Qualification / trap: Do not use 232 BCE as a universal end-date.

Hard MCQ 02 - Virtually subcontinental empire

Question: Why is the expression 'first virtually subcontinental empire' preferable to 'first uniformly all-India state'?

- (a) It denies that the north-west formed part of Mauryan political geography.
- (b) It recognises unprecedented scale while preserving the regional limits and graded character of control.
- (c) It treats every southern polity named in an edict as a directly governed province.
- (d) It means the Mauryas ruled only the middle Ganga valley.

Answer: B - It recognises unprecedented scale while preserving the regional limits and graded character of control. Explanation: Upinder's formulation captures both scale and qualification. Southern neighbours and peripheries should not be annexed merely because they appear in the edictal horizon, and control varied by core, corridor and frontier.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961 and Chapter 7 conclusion; Ashokan edict geography.

Qualification / trap: Scale and uniformity are not synonyms.

Hard MCQ 03 - Later-Maurya epigraphy

Question: Which later Maurya provides the clearest contemporary inscriptional bridge after Ashoka?

- (a) Samprati through a complete series of empire-wide pillar edicts.
- (b) Shalishuka through named silver portrait coins.
- (c) Dasharatha through the Nagarjuni cave inscriptions.
- (d) Brihadratha through a contemporary account of Pushyamitra's coup.

Answer: C - Dasharatha through the Nagarjuni cave inscriptions. Explanation: Upinder Singh states that Dasharatha is the only later Maurya known to have issued inscriptions. The Nagarjuni cave dedications also demonstrate selective continuation of Ajivika patronage after Ashoka.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; Nagarjuni cave inscriptions.

Qualification / trap: Later dynastic lists are not equivalent to contemporary inscriptions.

Hard MCQ 04 - Source hierarchy

Question: For reconstructing the precise post-Ashoka succession, which evidence problem is most serious?

- (a) Ashokan edicts provide a complete list of later rulers and their reign lengths.
- (b) Coins carry unambiguous portraits and names of every later Maurya.
- (c) Archaeological layers identify each successor and the exact year each province separated.
- (d) Puranic, Buddhist and Jain lists are later and divergent, while contemporary inscriptions become very sparse.

Answer: D - Puranic, Buddhist and Jain lists are later and divergent, while contemporary inscriptions become very sparse. Explanation: The post-Ashoka archive is thin. Traditions preserve names and memories but differ, archaeology supplies material sequences without automatically naming rulers, and Mauryan punch-marked coins are hard to assign to individuals.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; repository source-method conventions.

Qualification / trap: Chronological uncertainty must be stated, not filled with invented precision.

Hard MCQ 05 - Multilingual communication

Question: Which combination best represents Ashoka's regionally adapted public communication?

- (a) Prakrit-Brahmi across much of the empire, Kharoshthi in the north-west, and Greek/Aramaic versions in selected north-western contexts.
- (b) Sanskrit-Devanagari throughout the empire with no regional variation.
- (c) Tamil-Brahmi only in the Ganga valley and Greek only at Sarnath.
- (d) Pali-Kharoshthi in Kalinga and Latin-Aramaic at Pataliputra.

Answer: A - Prakrit-Brahmi across much of the empire, Kharoshthi in the north-west, and Greek/Aramaic versions in selected north-western contexts. Explanation: The script-language pattern is a key legacy of inscriptional governance and regional adaptation. It should not be converted into a simple ethnic map or proof of equal administrative penetration.

Named evidence: Ashokan inscriptional corpus; Topic 14 bounded evidence.

Qualification / trap: Most edicts were not in Sanskrit.

Hard MCQ 06 - National-symbol afterlife

Question: What is the strongest historical inference from the Sarnath lion capital's modern national-emblem status?

- (a) Every element of the modern emblem reproduces the ancient capital without adaptation.
- (b) A Mauryan monument acquired a new republican meaning, illustrating selective reinterpretation rather than institutional continuity.
- (c) The capital proves Ashoka governed through modern constitutional nationalism.
- (d) The Mauryan monarchy legally continued into the Indian republic.

Answer: B - A Mauryan monument acquired a new republican meaning, illustrating selective reinterpretation rather than institutional continuity. Explanation: ASI identifies the lion capital as Mauryan/Ashokan and a national crest, while Upinder highlights its modern political memory. The afterlife is symbolic and historiographical, not a survival of Mauryan sovereignty.

Named evidence: ASI Sarnath Circle; Upinder Singh p. 964.

Qualification / trap: Modern appropriation is not ancient institutional continuity.

Hard MCQ 07 - Sanchi layering

Question: Which statement about Sanchi most accurately demonstrates continuity through transformation?

- (a) All stone railings and gateways were completed by Ashoka.
- (b) Sanchi proves a total Buddhist rupture under the Shungas.
- (c) An Ashokan brick stupa and pillar were enlarged and embellished under later dynasties, so the visible complex is multi-period.
- (d) The site was abandoned immediately after 232 BCE and never received later patronage.

Answer: C - An Ashokan brick stupa and pillar were enlarged and embellished under later dynasties, so the visible complex is multi-period. Explanation: UNESCO distinguishes the Mauryan brick core and pillar from later Shunga enlargement and Satavahana gateway ornamentation. The site therefore refutes both 'all Ashokan' and 'total post-Mauryan rupture' narratives.

Named evidence: UNESCO Buddhist Monuments at Sanchi.

Qualification / trap: Always date monument layers separately.

Hard MCQ 08 - Cave patronage continuity

Question: Why are Dasharatha's Nagarjuni cave inscriptions especially valuable for Topic 15?

- (a) They document the Bactrian Greek invasion year by year.
- (b) They prove all Ashokan officials and provinces continued unchanged.
- (c) They establish a Brahmanical revolution immediately after Ashoka.
- (d) They provide contemporary evidence for later-Maurya royal patronage of Ajivikas after Ashoka.

Answer: D - They provide contemporary evidence for later-Maurya royal patronage of Ajivikas after Ashoka. Explanation: The inscriptions offer a rare post-Ashoka royal voice and complicate claims of instant religious reversal. Their reach is limited: cave donation does not map the later empire.

Named evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions; Upinder Singh p. 961.

Qualification / trap: A patronage inscription is not a territorial survey.

Hard MCQ 09 - Weak-successor theory

Question: Which is the strongest evidence supporting the weak-successor interpretation?

- (a) The first three long reigns were followed by many short reigns, with a sharp reduction in contemporary royal inscriptions.
- (b) A contemporary census ranks every later Maurya as incompetent.
- (c) Every province issued a dated declaration against each successor.
- (d) Ashoka ordered that no competent heir could succeed him.

Answer: A - The first three long reigns were followed by many short reigns, with a sharp reduction in contemporary royal inscriptions. Explanation: The reign pattern and epigraphic thinning support instability, but the adjective 'weak' often rests on later lists. A good answer treats succession as a trigger that interacted with structural and regional pressures.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961.

Qualification / trap: Short reigns suggest instability; they do not explain every mechanism.

Hard MCQ 10 - Limits of personality theory

Question: What is the best criticism of explaining Mauryan decline only through weak successors?

- (a) There is complete evidence that provincial institutions were wholly autonomous.
- (b) It does not explain why particular regions detached, how frontier pressure operated, or why material-economic processes continued.
- (c) The later Mauryas all had longer reigns than Chandragupta.
- (d) Ancient empires never depended on rulers.

Answer: B - It does not explain why particular regions detached, how frontier pressure operated, or why material-economic processes continued. Explanation: Ruler quality matters only through institutions, loyalties, armies and regions. The theory becomes persuasive when succession shocks are linked to integration costs and regional opportunities.

Named evidence: Multi-causal synthesis from Upinder Singh and repository answer architecture.

Qualification / trap: Biography must be converted into a mechanism.

Hard MCQ 11 - Centralisation mechanism

Question: Under a strongly centralised model, why would rapid succession be especially destabilising?

- (a) A centralised state requires no revenue or communication.
- (b) All local elites become politically irrelevant forever.
- (c) Appointments, reporting, military command and provincial loyalty would depend heavily on continuity at the centre.
- (d) Centralisation automatically abolishes distance.

Answer: C - Appointments, reporting, military command and provincial loyalty would depend heavily on continuity at the centre. Explanation: A top-heavy system magnifies the effects of court instability. However, this model must be qualified by evidence of local mediation and differentiated control.

Named evidence: Rock Edicts III and VI; centralisation debate in Topic 14.

Qualification / trap: Explain the transmission mechanism, not merely 'overcentralisation'.

Hard MCQ 12 - Differentiated-control implication

Question: If Mauryan rule was regionally differentiated rather than uniform, what follows for decline analysis?

- (a) The empire must be reclassified as a purely imaginary state.
- (b) No province could ever separate because it already had autonomy.
- (c) Weak rulers become completely irrelevant to every region.
- (d) Local mediation could reduce daily central burdens yet make political detachment easier when central prestige and coercion weakened.

Answer: D - Local mediation could reduce daily central burdens yet make political detachment easier when central prestige and coercion weakened. Explanation: Differentiation is double-edged: it can stabilise a large empire through intermediaries and create autonomous capacities that later support regionalisation. It does not erase strategic central power.

Named evidence: Fussman/Thapar differentiated-control debate; Upinder Singh p. 963.

Qualification / trap: Avoid both unitary-state and symbolic-empire extremes.

Hard MCQ 13 - Fiscal-crisis evidence

Question: Which verdict best reflects Upinder Singh's assessment of a Mauryan fiscal crisis?

- (a) Large imperial costs make strain plausible, but there is no direct evidence for either a state fiscal crisis or a wider economic crisis.
- (b) Coin hoards demonstrate that all taxes ceased after Ashoka.
- (c) Treasury accounts prove bankruptcy immediately after Kalinga.
- (d) The Arthashastra records the exact terminal Mauryan deficit.

Answer: A - Large imperial costs make strain plausible, but there is no direct evidence for either a state fiscal crisis or a wider economic crisis. Explanation: Upinder explicitly rejects claims of proven fiscal/economic crisis. Structural expenditure on army and officialdom can be discussed, but not converted into a documented bankruptcy.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962.

Qualification / trap: Plausible cost is not proven crisis.

Hard MCQ 14 - Army disbandment trap

Question: Which proposition is evidence-secure?

- (a) Rock Edict XIII records a constitutional ban on defensive force.
- (b) Ashoka renounced aggressive conquest but did not disband the army.
- (c) Ashoka abolished all military institutions after Kalinga.
- (d) Ashoka transferred the entire army to Buddhist monasteries.

Answer: B - Ashoka renounced aggressive conquest but did not disband the army. Explanation: Upinder stresses Ashoka's pragmatism: army, punishment and warnings remained. The pacifism thesis must therefore be framed as a possible preparedness issue, not demilitarisation.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962; Rock Edict XIII.

Qualification / trap: Renunciation of aggression is not abolition of defence.

Hard MCQ 15 - Capital punishment

Question: Which evidence most directly counters the claim that dhamma eliminated coercive kingship?

- (a) The Sarnath capital contains four lions.
- (b) The Rummindei inscription reduces a fiscal levy.
- (c) Pillar Edict IV presupposes capital punishment while regulating justice and reprieve.
- (d) The Bhabru edict recommends Buddhist texts.

Answer: C - Pillar Edict IV presupposes capital punishment while regulating justice and reprieve. Explanation: Pillar Edict IV shows reform and restraint within a punitive order. It is therefore relevant to decline debates that mistakenly equate dhamma with a powerless state.

Named evidence: Pillar Edict IV.

Qualification / trap: Ethical reform can coexist with coercion.

Hard MCQ 16 - Forest warning

Question: What does Ashoka's warning to forest peoples in Rock Edict XIII demonstrate?

- (a) Every forest community immediately joined the Mauryan army.
- (b) Ashoka withdrew from Kalinga and dissolved frontier administration.
- (c) The empire renounced punishment in all circumstances.
- (d) Remorse and dhamma-vijaya coexisted with retained deterrent power.

Answer: D - Remorse and dhamma-vijaya coexisted with retained deterrent power. Explanation: The warning is decisive counter-evidence to total-pacifism claims. It does not quantify military readiness, but it proves

coercion remained part of royal self-presentation.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII.

Qualification / trap: Use the warning as counter-evidence, not troop statistics.

Hard MCQ 17 - Brahmanical-reaction counter-evidence

Question: Which inscriptional pattern most strongly weakens an empirewide anti-Brahmana-policy thesis?

- (a) Ashoka repeatedly exhorted respect for both Brahmanas and shramanas.
- (b) Ashoka ordered the destruction of all Vedic texts.
- (c) Dasharatha prohibited Ajivika patronage.
- (d) Every edict was written exclusively for Buddhist monks.

Answer: A - Ashoka repeatedly exhorted respect for both Brahmanas and shramanas. Explanation: The edicts do not support blanket persecution of Brahmanas. Specific ritual grievances may be hypothesised, but the broad revolution thesis lacks inscriptional foundation.

Named evidence: Major Rock Edicts and Upinder Singh p. 962.

Qualification / trap: Do not infer persecution from heterodox patronage.

Hard MCQ 18 - Sacrifice restriction

Question: What is the most defensible use of Ashoka's restrictions on sacrifice in decline analysis?

- (a) They ended animal killing throughout the empire with complete compliance.
- (b) They may have displeased some ritual specialists, but the scale and political consequence of such grievance are unproven.
- (c) They prove every Brahmana joined Pushyamitra in a coordinated revolt.
- (d) They demonstrate that Brahmanas disappeared from Mauryan society.

Answer: B - They may have displeased some ritual specialists, but the scale and political consequence of such grievance are unproven. Explanation: Upinder allows the possibility of grievance among Brahmanas dependent on sacrifice, but balances it with explicit respect for Brahmanas and plural patronage. The mechanism remains bounded.

Named evidence: Rock Edict I and Upinder Singh p. 962.

Qualification / trap: Possible grievance is not proven revolution.

Hard MCQ 19 - Pushyamitra coup

Question: What can the Pushyamitra-Brihadratha transition establish most securely?

- (a) Every Mauryan province simultaneously revolted for religious reasons.
- (b) Ashoka had selected Pushyamitra as his successor.
- (c) A military commander replaced the last Maurya in the conventional dynastic narrative; it does not by itself explain earlier empirewide disintegration.
- (d) The economy collapsed on the day of the coup.

Answer: C - A military commander replaced the last Maurya in the conventional dynastic narrative; it does not by itself explain earlier empirewide disintegration. Explanation: The coup marks dynastic termination at the centre after a longer weakening process. Pushyamitra's Brahmana identity and Vedic rites concern successor legitimisation, not automatic proof of the cause of imperial decline.

Named evidence: Later dynastic tradition; Master Chronology.

Qualification / trap: Final event and long causal process must be separated.

Hard MCQ 20 - Persecution traditions

Question: How should Buddhist narratives of Pushyamitra's persecution be handled?

- (a) As modern archaeological reports.
- (b) As Ashokan edicts issued by Pushyamitra.
- (c) As official UPSC answer keys.
- (d) As later sectarian memories requiring corroboration, not as self-verifying contemporary chronicles.

Answer: D - As later sectarian memories requiring corroboration, not as self-verifying contemporary chronicles. Explanation: The narratives matter for memory and religious conflict, but date, genre and purpose limit their direct causal use. Archaeology such as continued Sanchi activity complicates a total-rupture reading.

Named evidence: Later Buddhist traditions; Sanchi archaeological continuity.

Qualification / trap: Source criticism is not dismissal; it defines evidentiary reach.

Hard MCQ 21 - Taxila complaint source

Question: The famous Taxila complaints against wicked officials are best classified as:

- (a) Later Buddhist narrative evidence preserving a memory of centre-province conflict.
- (b) A contemporary Ashokan pillar edict from Taxila.
- (c) An Indo-Greek bilingual coin legend.
- (d) A Puranic fiscal schedule.

Answer: A - Later Buddhist narrative evidence preserving a memory of centre-province conflict. Explanation: Divyavadana/Ashokavadana traditions are useful for remembered administrative oppression but are not contemporary administrative files. They should be paired with direct Kalinga edictal concern.

Named evidence: Divyavadana/Ashokavadana tradition; Sharma p. 208.

Qualification / trap: Always name the later narrative genre.

Hard MCQ 22 - Kalinga justice edicts

Question: What do the Separate Kalinga Edicts establish most directly?

- (a) All officials across the empire were removed.
- (b) Ashoka was concerned about arbitrary imprisonment, official behaviour, confidence and just administration in a conquered province.
- (c) The death penalty was abolished throughout India.
- (d) Kalinga successfully expelled the Mauryas immediately after the war.

Answer: B - Ashoka was concerned about arbitrary imprisonment, official behaviour, confidence and just administration in a conquered province. Explanation: The edicts reveal corrective governance and the principal-agent problem. They do not document a later Kalinga revolt or prove that reforms succeeded.

Named evidence: Separate Kalinga Edicts I-II.

Qualification / trap: Royal concern is not the same as verified compliance.

Hard MCQ 23 - Regional agency

Question: Which statement best captures provincial assertion in a multi-causal model?

- (a) All regions waited passively for Pushyamitra's coup.
- (b) Provincial agency rules out any role for frontier invasion.
- (c) Regional elites could redirect revenue, troops and legitimacy when succession and central coordination weakened.
- (d) Regional states had no connection with earlier routes or material culture.

Answer: C - Regional elites could redirect revenue, troops and legitimacy when succession and central coordination weakened. Explanation: Regional actors converted structural opportunity into new polities. This mechanism interacts with weak succession, communication costs and frontier pressure rather than replacing them.

Named evidence: Regional successor evidence; Sharma pp. 208-211.

Qualification / trap: Regions are agents, not empty spaces on an imperial map.

Hard MCQ 24 - Dasharatha and religious plurality

Question: What does Dasharatha's dedication of Nagarjuni caves to Ajivikas most strongly imply?

- (a) Brahmanical reaction was complete in 232 BCE.
- (b) Buddhism was legally banned after Ashoka.
- (c) Dasharatha restored the empire to Ashoka's full extent.
- (d) Some Mauryan traditions of plural royal patronage continued after Ashoka.

Answer: D - Some Mauryan traditions of plural royal patronage continued after Ashoka. Explanation: The dedication is narrow but important contemporary evidence. It counters claims of an immediate, total orthodox reversal while revealing nothing certain about the full territorial state.

Named evidence: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions.

Qualification / trap: Use precise continuity, not sweeping continuity.

Hard MCQ 25 - Bactrian Greek pressure

Question: Which external factor does Upinder Singh explicitly identify as further weakening the Mauryan Empire?

- (a) An invasion by the Bactrian Greeks.
- (b) A Roman naval blockade of Pataliputra.
- (c) A Gupta conquest of Taxila.
- (d) A Kushana invasion during Ashoka's reign.

Answer: A - An invasion by the Bactrian Greeks. Explanation: Bactrian Greek pressure is one of the firmer externally framed contributors in the consulted synthesis. Its strongest direct explanatory reach is the north-west.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961.

Qualification / trap: Frontier pressure must be regionally bounded.

Hard MCQ 26 - Frontier chronology

Question: How should Sharma's c. 206 BCE Greek-invasion date be used?

- (a) As the date Ashoka disbanded his army.
- (b) As a conventional textbook chronology placed before the dynastic end, with source and regional qualification.
- (c) As an exact date proving all provinces fell on the same day.
- (d) As evidence that Alexander personally destroyed the Mauryas.

Answer: B - As a conventional textbook chronology placed before the dynastic end, with source and regional qualification. Explanation: The date helps sequence north-western pressure, but it should not be treated as a complete all-India decline chronology. Upinder's wording remains more general.

Named evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 209-210; Upinder Singh p. 961.

Qualification / trap: Use exact dates only at the confidence level of the source.

Hard MCQ 27 - North-western exposure

Question: Why was the north-west a distinct decline zone?

- (a) It had no cities or trade routes.
- (b) It was the only region where Ashoka issued Brahmi inscriptions.
- (c) It faced trans-Hindu Kush political pressure, frontier-route competition and a history of multilingual local mediation.
- (d) It lay outside all Hellenistic connections.

Answer: C - It faced trans-Hindu Kush political pressure, frontier-route competition and a history of multilingual local mediation. Explanation: Taxila-Gandhara linked the subcontinent to Bactria and western/central Asia. Its frontier dynamics cannot be generalised mechanically to Kalinga or the Deccan.

Named evidence: Kandahar/Shahbazgarhi/Mansehra evidence; Topic 16 bounded context.

Qualification / trap: One regional cause does not become an all-India cause.

Hard MCQ 28 - Regional differentiation

Question: Which paired transition is most accurate?

- (a) Kalinga: Gupta rule in 320 BCE; centre: Chola conquest.
- (b) Deccan: immediate Kushana rule; north-west: Satavahana rule.
- (c) Far south: direct Shunga province; north-west: no successor polity.
- (d) North-west: Bactrian/Indo-Greek pressure; Ganga-centre: later Mauryas followed by Shunga transition.

Answer: D - North-west: Bactrian/Indo-Greek pressure; Ganga-centre: later Mauryas followed by Shunga transition. Explanation: Post-Mauryan outcomes were asynchronous and regional. The pair preserves the principal geographical contrast without claiming exact dates for every local separation.

Named evidence: Master Chronology; Topics 16-17 bounded context.

Qualification / trap: Build a regional map, not a single queue.

Hard MCQ 29 - Economic-continuity verdict

Question: Which statement best represents Upinder Singh's economic conclusion?

- (a) Agrarian expansion, urbanisation, trade and the money economy continued; political decline should not be equated with economy-wide collapse.
- (b) Coin use ceased throughout India in 232 BCE.
- (c) The post-Mauryan period had no long-distance commerce.
- (d) All cities were abandoned immediately after Ashoka.

Answer: A - Agrarian expansion, urbanisation, trade and the money economy continued; political decline should not be equated with economy-wide collapse. Explanation: The broad processes crossed dynastic boundaries and expanded in many post-Mauryan regions. Local contraction remains possible but requires site-specific evidence.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 963-965.

Qualification / trap: Dynastic chronology is not automatically economic chronology.

Hard MCQ 30 - Coins as evidence

Question: What can a post-Mauryan coin hoard most safely establish?

- (a) Universal replacement of barter by coin.
- (b) Circulation, accumulation and political/economic activity in a specific context, not an all-India prosperity rate.
- (c) The exact GDP of the issuing dynasty.
- (d) The date every Mauryan official lost office.

Answer: B - Circulation, accumulation and political/economic activity in a specific context, not an all-India prosperity rate. Explanation: Coins are powerful for authority, iconography, chronology and exchange, but require archaeological context. Mauryan punch-marked coins are especially difficult to assign to individual rulers.

Named evidence: Numismatic method; Topics 14 and 16.

Qualification / trap: Coins are not fiscal accounts or GDP.

Hard MCQ 31 - Urban archaeology

Question: Which archaeological pattern most strongly challenges a sudden 'economic collapse' narrative?

- (a) A single later literary claim about an empty treasury.
- (b) The disappearance of every settlement after 232 BCE.
- (c) Urban layers, craft activity, brick/ring-well use and coin circulation continue across Mauryan and post-Mauryan phases at multiple centres.
- (d) The absence of a modern census.

Answer: C - Urban layers, craft activity, brick/ring-well use and coin circulation continue across Mauryan and post-Mauryan phases at multiple centres. Explanation: Material continuities and later urban growth show restructuring rather than universal collapse. Each site's stratigraphy must still be dated separately.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh conclusion; early-historic archaeology.

Qualification / trap: Use site, phase and indicator.

Hard MCQ 32 - Material diffusion hypothesis

Question: How does Sharma connect Mauryan significance with later regionalisation?

- (a) Regional states arose without agrarian or material bases.
- (b) Mauryas prevented iron and brick technology from leaving Pataliputra.
- (c) Every successor copied the Mauryan constitution word for word.
- (d) The spread of material culture and state knowledge reduced Magadha's special advantage and enabled new regional states.

Answer: D - The spread of material culture and state knowledge reduced Magadha's special advantage and enabled new regional states. Explanation: Sharma links iron/steel, bricks, ring wells, routes and state-forming knowledge with the rise of regional powers. The argument is enabling, not technologically deterministic.

Named evidence: R. S. Sharma pp. 204-208.

Qualification / trap: Legacy can become a condition of decentralisation.

Hard MCQ 33 - Technology and determinism

Question: Why is 'iron caused Mauryan collapse' an unsafe proposition?

- (a) Technology can enable agrarian and military capacity only through local institutions, elites, labour and networks.
- (b) Iron was unknown anywhere in Mauryan India.
- (c) Technologies never affect political change.
- (d) All iron artefacts belong to the Gupta age.

Answer: A - Technology can enable agrarian and military capacity only through local institutions, elites, labour and networks. Explanation: Wider iron use may have reduced regional asymmetry, but it cannot independently explain succession, frontier invasion or political legitimacy. The causal language must remain conditional.

Named evidence: Sharma's material-diffusion hypothesis, qualified.

Qualification / trap: Capacity enables; it does not determine.

Hard MCQ 34 - Ecological hypothesis

Question: Which conclusion is most evidence-disciplined regarding ecology and Mauryan decline?

- (a) Climate had no relevance to transport or agrarian extraction.
- (b) Terrain, rainfall, forests and distance affected control costs, but no single terminal ecological shock is established in the consulted evidence.
- (c) A proven empirewide drought ended the dynasty in exactly 185 BCE.
- (d) The Great Wall of China caused monsoon failure in Magadha.

Answer: B - Terrain, rainfall, forests and distance affected control costs, but no single terminal ecological shock is established in the consulted evidence. Explanation: Ecology is a structural modifier of routes, settlement and surveillance. Without dated palaeoenvironmental evidence, it should not be elevated into a master cause.

Named evidence: Repository source limits; no terminal ecological event in consulted books.

Qualification / trap: Do not invent a climate-collapse narrative.

Hard MCQ 35 - Routes as paradox

Question: Why can imperial routes be interpreted as both significance and vulnerability?

- (a) Routes operated without labour, revenue or local cooperation.
- (b) Routes disappeared as soon as one ruler died.
- (c) They enabled movement of officials, goods and messages, but required protection and could later channel regional autonomy or invasion.
- (d) Routes made distance irrelevant.

Answer: C - They enabled movement of officials, goods and messages, but required protection and could later channel regional autonomy or invasion. Explanation: Network infrastructure is politically ambivalent. Strong authority converts corridors into integration; weakened authority may lose strategic nodes while exchange continues.

Named evidence: Sharma pp. 202-206; inscription geography.

Qualification / trap: Infrastructure does not guarantee permanent sovereignty.

Hard MCQ 36 - Shunga transition

Question: Which is the safest description of the Shungas in relation to Mauryan decline?

- (a) They immediately restored Ashoka's full territorial empire.
- (b) They were an Indo-Greek dynasty based in Bactria.
- (c) They prove a simultaneous anti-Buddhist uprising across the subcontinent.
- (d) They replaced the last Maurya in the Ganga-central political zone and participated in post-Mauryan cultural patronage, without ruling every former Mauryan region.

Answer: D - They replaced the last Maurya in the Ganga-central political zone and participated in post-Mauryan cultural patronage, without ruling every former Mauryan region. Explanation: The Shunga transition is central to dynastic termination but must be regionalised. Sanchi activity and debated persecution traditions complicate simple religious-rupture narratives.

Named evidence: Master Chronology; UNESCO Sanchi; later traditions.

Qualification / trap: Do not turn a central successor into an all-India replacement.

Hard MCQ 37 - Kanva sequence

Question: Where do the Kanvas fit in the bounded transition?

- (a) They followed the Shungas in the middle-Ganga/central political sequence and represent continued regional kingship.
- (b) They were the first Bactrian Greek coin issuers.
- (c) They preceded Chandragupta Maurya.
- (d) They were Ashokan district officers.

Answer: A - They followed the Shungas in the middle-Ganga/central political sequence and represent continued regional kingship. Explanation: The Kanvas matter as one successor dynasty, not as a separate master cause of Mauryan decline. Their history is short and textually reconstructed.

Named evidence: Master Chronology; Sharma pp. 209-211.

Qualification / trap: Keep successor detail proportional to the question.

Hard MCQ 38 - Indo-Greek transition

Question: Which evidence class most clearly marks new named political authority in the post-Mauryan north-west?

- (a) Anonymous Mauryan pillar polish alone.
- (b) Attributable Indo-Greek coinage with ruler names and bilingual legends.
- (c) Later Vedic sacrificial texts.
- (d) Sanchi's Gupta shrines.

Answer: B - Attributable Indo-Greek coinage with ruler names and bilingual legends. Explanation: Indo-Greek coins are important for chronology, sovereignty and cultural contact. They should not be used to claim immediate rule over all former Mauryan territory.

Named evidence: Topic 16 bounded numismatic context.

Qualification / trap: Attributable coinage is regionally powerful evidence.

Hard MCQ 39 - Satavahana chronology

Question: What is the most defensible relationship between Mauryan decline and Satavahana rise?

- (a) They inherited every Mauryan province without change.
- (b) The Satavahanas took Pataliputra in 232 BCE.
- (c) Mauryan contact helped shape a Deccan state-forming environment, but Satavahana origins and early chronology are debated and not an instant replacement.
- (d) Their entire history is known from Ashokan edicts.

Answer: C - Mauryan contact helped shape a Deccan state-forming environment, but Satavahana origins and early chronology are debated and not an instant replacement. Explanation: Prakrit-Brahmi use, administrative terms and routes show selective continuity, while inscriptions, coins and Puranic lists reveal a distinct networked Deccan polity.

Named evidence: Topics 17 basic/advanced; Sharma pp. 206-208.

Qualification / trap: Successor does not mean constitutional clone.

Hard MCQ 40 - Kalinga regionalisation

Question: How should later Chetis/Mahameghavahanas be used in a Mauryan-decline answer?

- (a) As Bactrian Greek governors of Taxila.
- (b) As the dynasty that built the Sarnath lion capital.
- (c) As the authors of Ashoka's Separate Kalinga Edicts.
- (d) As evidence of longer-term Kalinga regional state formation, not as contemporary proof of an immediate post-Ashoka revolt.

Answer: D - As evidence of longer-term Kalinga regional state formation, not as contemporary proof of an immediate post-Ashoka revolt. Explanation: Later Kalinga evidence, including the Hathigumpha world, demonstrates regional agency but sits at a chronological distance from Ashoka. It should support transformation, not a precise revolt date.

Named evidence: Sharma pp. 206-208; bounded post-Mauryan context.

Qualification / trap: Later regional success cannot date earlier separation automatically.

Hard MCQ 41 - Overlapping successors

Question: Which model best represents the post-Mauryan political landscape?

- (a) Overlapping regional polities with different chronologies in the Ganga centre, north-west, Kalinga and Deccan.
- (b) A simple sequence of Shunga, Satavahana and Indo-Greek all-India empires.
- (c) A complete absence of states for two centuries.
- (d) One successor dynasty ruling the entire former empire at a time.

Answer: A - Overlapping regional polities with different chronologies in the Ganga centre, north-west, Kalinga and Deccan. Explanation: Regionalisation is asynchronous. The examination map should show simultaneous worlds and transition zones rather than a single dynastic ladder.

Named evidence: Master Chronology; Topics 16-17.

Qualification / trap: Map overlap, not false succession order.

Hard MCQ 42 - Administrative vocabulary

Question: What does the later use of terms such as mahamatra most safely suggest?

- (a) The Mauryan central government survived legally under every successor.
- (b) Administrative vocabulary and prestige could travel, but functions and institutions must be re-established in each polity.
- (c) All officers had identical duties from Ashoka to the Satavahanas.
- (d) Vocabulary has no historical value.

Answer: B - Administrative vocabulary and prestige could travel, but functions and institutions must be re-established in each polity. Explanation: Shared terminology is evidence of cultural-administrative memory and adaptation, not proof of unchanged bureaucratic structure. Context, inscription and region determine function.

Named evidence: Topic 17 inscriptions; Topic 14 officer vocabulary.

Qualification / trap: Name continuity is not institutional identity.

Hard MCQ 43 - Epigraphic precedent

Question: Which long-term Mauryan legacy is best captured by widespread Prakrit-Brahmi public inscriptions?

- (a) The disappearance of oral proclamation.
- (b) A permanent ban on Sanskrit inscriptions.
- (c) The use of durable writing in political, ethical, donative and administrative communication by later patrons.
- (d) A single unchanged imperial language policy until the medieval period.

Answer: C - The use of durable writing in political, ethical, donative and administrative communication by later patrons. Explanation: Ashoka's programme was unprecedented in scale, and later inscriptions adopted different genres and languages. The legacy is epigraphic political technology, not textual uniformity.

Named evidence: Ashokan corpus; post-Mauryan inscriptions.

Qualification / trap: Legacy is a repertoire, not a frozen template.

Hard MCQ 44 - Dhamma as foundational concept

Question: According to Upinder Singh, what is foundational about Ashoka's use of dhamma?

- (a) He invented every earlier meaning of dharma.
- (b) He converted all subjects to one Buddhist school.
- (c) He abolished hierarchy and royal paternalism.
- (d) He made moral foundations, social conflict and religious concord central public questions of kingship.

Answer: D - He made moral foundations, social conflict and religious concord central public questions of kingship. Explanation: Ashoka appropriated and reworked a wider concept through a distinctive imperial ethical programme. Upinder stresses both its foundational political importance and its radical aspects.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 963-964.

Qualification / trap: Foundational does not mean sole origin or modern equality.

Hard MCQ 45 - Stone-masonry legacy

Question: Which statement best captures the significance of Mauryan stone art?

- (a) Large-scale polished stone, pillars and rock-cut beginnings made power and patronage durable and transportable, while later traditions transformed the forms.
- (b) Mauryas invented stone as a material in South Asia.
- (c) Mauryan art had no religious or popular dimension.
- (d) Every polished stone object is securely Mauryan.

Answer: A - Large-scale polished stone, pillars and rock-cut beginnings made power and patronage durable and transportable, while later traditions transformed the forms. Explanation: The achievement lies in scale, engineering, workmanship and ideological placement, not a claim that stone was previously unknown. Polish alone is not a secure date.

Named evidence: Sharma pp. 203-205; Upinder Chapter 7.

Qualification / trap: Avoid invention claims and polish-only dating.

Hard MCQ 46 - Cultural contact

Question: How should Achaemenid/Hellenistic elements in Mauryan art be discussed?

- (a) As proof that Mauryan art was a foreign copy with no Indian agency.
- (b) As evidence of travelling motifs and techniques transformed through local workshops, meanings and patronage.
- (c) As evidence that all pillars were carved in Greece.
- (d) As proof that no artistic contact occurred.

Answer: B - As evidence of travelling motifs and techniques transformed through local workshops, meanings and patronage. Explanation: Influence analysis must compare specific forms, technologies and meanings. Similarity and innovation can coexist, and imported/indigenous binaries are too crude.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh artistic-influence discussion, Chapter 7.

Qualification / trap: Name the form and transformation.

Hard MCQ 47 - Ashoka's memory

Question: Which source-use rule is most appropriate for Buddhist Ashoka traditions?

- (a) Treat them as Mauryan treasury ledgers.
- (b) Accept every miracle and number as contemporary fact.
- (c) Use them to study sectarian memory and later political-religious ideals, while testing historical claims against inscriptions and archaeology.
- (d) Discard them entirely because they are later.

Answer: C - Use them to study sectarian memory and later political-religious ideals, while testing historical claims against inscriptions and archaeology. Explanation: Later traditions are historically valuable for reception and memory. Source criticism limits their use for precise succession, administration or chronology without making them irrelevant.

Named evidence: Ashokavadana and Sri Lankan chronicle traditions, source-criticised.

Qualification / trap: Source criticism defines use; it does not mean automatic rejection.

Hard MCQ 48 - Theory ranking

Question: Which ordering best reflects evidentiary strength in the consulted sources?

- (a) Brahmanical revolution alone is certain; all other factors are irrelevant.
- (b) Ecological disaster is certain; succession is unsupported.
- (c) Economic collapse is officially documented; frontier pressure is imaginary.
- (d) Succession instability and strained integration, with regional/frontier pressures, are stronger than proven fiscal collapse or empirewide religious revolution.

Answer: D - Succession instability and strained integration, with regional/frontier pressures, are stronger than proven fiscal collapse or empirewide religious revolution. Explanation: The strongest synthesis ranks, rather than equalises, causes. Weak successors, imperial strain and Bactrian pressure are explicit; fiscal and religious master theories face strong counter-evidence.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 961-963; Sharma hypotheses critically tested.

Qualification / trap: A multi-causal answer still needs hierarchy.

Remedial MCQ 49 - Pacifism correction

Question: Which statement must be rejected?

- (a) Ashoka disbanded the Mauryan army after Kalinga.
- (b) Ashoka retained coercive warnings to forest peoples.
- (c) Pillar Edict IV presupposes capital punishment.
- (d) Ashoka preferred dhamma-vijaya to aggressive conquest.

Answer: A - Ashoka disbanded the Mauryan army after Kalinga. Explanation: No inscription or consulted historian supports army disbandment. This is the package's highest-priority factual correction.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962; Rock Edict XIII; Pillar Edict IV.

Qualification / trap: Do not equate remorse with demilitarisation.

Remedial MCQ 50 - Single-cause correction

Question: Which is the best response to 'Mauryan decline had one decisive cause'?

- (a) Treat every cause as proven and equal.
- (b) The regional chronology and unequal evidence require a multi-causal, interaction-based explanation.
- (c) Choose the longest textbook paragraph.
- (d) Ignore frontier and regional differences.

Answer: B - The regional chronology and unequal evidence require a multi-causal, interaction-based explanation. Explanation: A strong answer links structural strain, succession, regional agency and frontier pressure, then ranks weaker amplifiers.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh pp. 961-963.

Qualification / trap: Multi-causal does not mean unranked list.

Remedial MCQ 51 - 232 BCE correction

Question: What occurred in 232 BCE in the standard chronology?

- (a) The Indo-Greeks conquered the entire subcontinent.
- (b) Pushyamitra founded the Shunga dynasty that same year.
- (c) Ashoka died; the Maurya dynasty continued under later rulers.
- (d) Every Mauryan inscriptional site was abandoned.

Answer: C - Ashoka died; the Maurya dynasty continued under later rulers. Explanation: The dynasty conventionally ends c. 187/185 BCE. Confusing ruler death with dynastic and imperial termination distorts the chronology.

Named evidence: Master Chronology; Upinder Singh p. 961.

Qualification / trap: Three clocks: ruler, dynasty, integration.

Remedial MCQ 52 - Terminal-date correction

Question: Which formulation is safest for the Mauryan dynastic end?

- (a) Exactly 206 BCE as an all-India end.
- (b) Exactly 232 BCE without qualification.
- (c) AD 78 because of the Shaka era.
- (d) c. 187 BCE in Upinder Singh, often c. 185 BCE in textbook convention.

Answer: D - c. 187 BCE in Upinder Singh, often c. 185 BCE in textbook convention. Explanation: The package preserves the source conflict rather than inventing false precision. c. 206 BCE belongs to Sharma's Greek-invasion chronology, not the final dynastic date.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961; Sharma p. 210.

Qualification / trap: State the convention and source.

Remedial MCQ 53 - Sanchi correction

Question: Which visible Sanchi features should not be automatically credited to Ashoka?

- (a) The later stone casing, railings and ornate gateways.
- (b) The Ashokan pillar at the site.
- (c) The Mauryan brick stupa core.
- (d) The site's 3rd-century BCE Mauryan inception.

Answer: A - The later stone casing, railings and ornate gateways. Explanation: UNESCO attributes enlargement and embellishment to later Shunga and Satavahana phases. Layering is a core art-history trap.

Named evidence: UNESCO Sanchi.

Qualification / trap: Date layers, not just sites.

Remedial MCQ 54 - Fiscal-crisis correction

Question: Which claim is not established by the consulted evidence?

- (a) Taxation and regulation were important Mauryan features.
- (b) A documented empirewide late-Mauryan economic collapse.
- (c) State-specific strain is structurally plausible.
- (d) Maintaining army and officials was costly.

Answer: B - A documented empirewide late-Mauryan economic collapse. Explanation: Upinder states there is no evidence for a fiscal or wider economic crisis. The distinction between cost, strain and crisis is essential.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962.

Qualification / trap: Do not promote hypothesis to fact.

Remedial MCQ 55 - Brahmanical-reaction correction

Question: Which conclusion best fits the evidence?

- (a) Dasharatha ended all heterodox patronage.
- (b) Ashoka's edicts prove persecution of all Brahmanas.
- (c) Some ritual grievance is possible, but an empirewide Brahmanical revolution is not demonstrated.
- (d) Pushyamitra's caste identity proves every province revolted.

Answer: C - Some ritual grievance is possible, but an empirewide Brahmanical revolution is not demonstrated. Explanation: Ashoka repeatedly respected Brahmanas and Dasharatha continued Ajivika patronage. Sastri's key edict reading is rejected by Upinder.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 962; Nagarjuni inscriptions.

Qualification / trap: Identity of successor is not sufficient causation.

Remedial MCQ 56 - Taxila-source correction

Question: Taxila's complaint against wicked officials is not:

- (a) A claim requiring source criticism.
- (b) Potential evidence of a principal-agent problem.
- (c) A later Buddhist narrative memory.
- (d) A contemporary Ashokan inscription.

Answer: D - A contemporary Ashokan inscription. Explanation: The story is useful but belongs to later Buddhist narrative traditions. Pair it with the direct Kalinga edictal concern for a balanced argument.

Named evidence: Divyavadana/Ashokavadana; Sharma p. 208.

Qualification / trap: Genre before inference.

Remedial MCQ 57 - Dasharatha correction

Question: Which post-Ashoka ruler is securely inscriptionally attested?

- (a) Dasharatha.
- (b) Pushyamitra as a Maurya king.
- (c) Brihadratha through a contemporary coup inscription.
- (d) Samprati through empire-wide edicts.

Answer: A - Dasharatha. Explanation: Dasharatha's Nagarjuni cave inscriptions are the key later-Maurya anchor. Other successor information is largely traditional.

Named evidence: Upinder Singh p. 961.

Qualification / trap: Keep the one secure name secure.

Remedial MCQ 58 - Successor-map correction

Question: Which statement is correct?

- (a) Shungas ruled the entire former Mauryan south.
- (b) Shungas, Indo-Greeks and Satavahana processes overlapped regionally rather than forming one all-India sequence.
- (c) No state existed between Mauryas and Guptas.
- (d) The Indo-Greeks succeeded the Satavahanas in the Deccan.

Answer: B - Shungas, Indo-Greeks and Satavahana processes overlapped regionally rather than forming one all-India sequence. Explanation: The post-Mauryan world is a map of simultaneous regional trajectories. This correction prevents chronological and spatial flattening.

Named evidence: Master Chronology; Topics 16-17.

Qualification / trap: Overlap, region and bounded chronology.

Remedial MCQ 59 - Legacy correction

Question: What does 'Mauryan administrative legacy' not mean?

- (a) Public inscription remained an important technology.
- (b) Routes and material forms could be reused.
- (c) Every office retained the same hierarchy and function under all successor states.
- (d) Some titles and political practices travelled.

Answer: C - Every office retained the same hierarchy and function under all successor states. Explanation: Continuity is selective and transformed. Shared vocabulary needs polity-specific inscriptional corroboration.

Named evidence: Topic 17 bounded evidence; continuity framework.

Qualification / trap: Name continuity is not institutional identity.

Remedial MCQ 60 - Source-class correction

Question: Which pairing is correct?

- (a) Inscriptions - complete compliance; archaeology - named rulers automatically; traditions - contemporary budgets; coins - GDP.
- (b) Inscriptions - climate data only; archaeology - official keys; traditions - exact borders; coins - no historical use.
- (c) All sources - identical date, audience and purpose.
- (d) Inscriptions - royal voice; archaeology - material pattern; traditions - later memory; coins - circulation and authority.

Answer: D - Inscriptions - royal voice; archaeology - material pattern; traditions - later memory; coins - circulation and authority. Explanation: The pairing states the proper evidentiary reach of each archive and prevents overclaiming.

Named evidence: Repository source-method standard.

Qualification / trap: Ask what a source can and cannot prove.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ 01 - 2019 Prelims GS-I Q8: Ranyo Ashoka portrait inscription

Question: In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka) mentioned along with the stone portrait of Ashoka?

- (A) Kanganahalli
- (B) Sanchi
- (C) Shahbazgarhi
- (D) Sohgaure

Answer/status: A - Kanganahalli

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper controls wording; the official key is not held locally.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Kanganahalli	Raya/Ranyo Asoko label with royal relief	Correct site and memory evidence	Relief is centuries later, not a lifetime portrait
Sanchi	Ashoka scenes in later relief interpretation	Important Buddhist memory	Not the labelled relief asked
Shahbazgarhi	Kharoshthi Major Rock Edicts	Ashokan public epigraphy	No portrait relief
Sohgaure	Debated early-historic plaque	Administrative/economic history	No Ashoka portrait inscription

Solved analysis

- The answer is Kanganahalli, where a labelled royal relief identifies Ashoka.
- Its significance for Topic 15 is memory: the relief was made long after Ashoka and shows how Buddhist communities visualised a remembered emperor.
- The other options belong to distinct evidence classes - stupa art, rock edicts and an administrative plaque.

Why this earns marks: It identifies the artefact, distinguishes historical memory from eyewitness portraiture, and eliminates distractors by source class.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat "In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka)..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka)..." add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 02 - 2020 Prelims GS-I Q30: Sectarian concord inscription

Question: Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever praises his religious sect or blames other sects out of excessive devotion to his own sect, with the view of glorifying his own sect, he rather injures his own sect very severely'?

- (A) Ashoka
- (B) Samudragupta
- (C) Harshavardhana
- (D) Krishnadeva Raya

Answer/status: A - Ashoka

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The wording is from the local official paper; no local official key is held.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Source	Major Rock Edict XII	Restraint in self-praise and condemnation	Translations vary
Positive ideal	Listening and growth in essentials of all sects	Concord beyond passive tolerance	Royal ideal is not proof of harmony
Policy	Respect for Brahmanas and shramanas	Counters anti-Brahmana/purely sectarian reading	Paternal authority remains
Legacy	Public political ethics through inscription	Foundational significance	Reception remains uncertain

Solved analysis

- The quotation condenses Major Rock Edict XII and therefore identifies Ashoka.
- Its significance lies in converting sectarian restraint and mutual listening into a public political ethic.
- It also directly weakens claims that Ashoka pursued a blanket anti-Brahmana policy.

Why this earns marks: It anchors the key to a named edict, explains its political-ethical significance and uses it as counter-evidence in a decline debate.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat "Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever...' as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever...', add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 03 - 2022 Prelims GS-I Q91: Major Rock Edict site-state pairs

Question: Consider the pairs: Dhauli-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-Karnataka. How many are correctly matched?

- (A) Only one pair
- (B) Only two pairs
- (C) Only three pairs
- (D) All four pairs

Answer/status: B - Only two pairs

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Dhuli	Odisha	Correct; Kalinga context	Modern administrative names can change
Erragudi/Yerragudi	Andhra Pradesh	Correct; major/minor edict context	Spelling varies
Jaugada	Odisha, not Madhya Pradesh	Kalinga pair with Dhuli	Do not infer from unfamiliarity
Kalsi	Uttarakhand, not Karnataka	Himalayan-foothill route	Phonetic similarity is a trap

Solved analysis

- Only Dhuli-Odisha and Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh are correct.
- The question tests the geography of inscriptional communication, a central Mauryan significance.
- Dhuli and Jaugada should be paired mentally as Kalinga sites; Kalsi belongs to Uttarakhand.

Why this earns marks: It supplies exact corrections and converts map recall into an interpretation of routes, regions and inscriptional governance.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat “Consider the pairs: Dhuli-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-...” as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For “Consider the pairs: Dhuli-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-...”, add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 04 - 2025 Prelims GS-I Q19: Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta

Question: Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important officers at which level?

- (A) Village-level administration
- (B) District-level administration
- (C) Provincial administration
- (D) Central administration

Answer/status: B - District-level administration

Verification: OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. The local UPSC 2025 Series-A key marks Q19 as B.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Pradeshika	Rock Edict III tour context	District-level field role	Not a modern district magistrate
Rajuka	Land/justice/welfare responsibilities	Delegated field authority	Function changed by context
Yukta	Executive/accounting-administrative role	Operational official	Exact hierarchy debated
Collective	Five-year tours	District administration and supervision	Titles were not identical

Solved analysis

- The officially verified answer is district-level administration.
- For significance, the grouping shows a visible field-administrative vocabulary and inspection network.
- For decline, dependence on periodic tours also reveals the costs of supervising distant officials.

Why this earns marks: It uses the official key, names the inscriptional context and extracts both significance and vulnerability without modernising the titles.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat “Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important...” as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For “Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important...”, add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 05 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q42: Stupa origin and function

Question: With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin; (2) Stupa was generally a repository of relics; (3) Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition. How many statements are correct?

- (A) Only one
- (B) Only two
- (C) All three
- (D) None

Answer/status: B - Only two

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included for Mauryan/post-Mauryan legacy.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Statement 1	Funerary mound tradition predates/exceeds Buddhism	Incorrect	Buddhism transformed/popularised the form
Statement 2	Relic enshrinement	Correct for many stupas	Not universal
Statement 3	Votive/commemorative role	Correct	Functions vary by period/site
Mauryan link	Sanchi brick core and Ashokan pillar	Imperial patronage	Visible stone/torana phases are later

Solved analysis

- Statements 2 and 3 are correct; the mound form is not exclusively Buddhist in origin.
- Ashoka's importance lies in patronage, enlargement and inscriptional commemoration, not invention of the stupa.
- Sanchi's Mauryan core and later additions make it a model of continuity through transformation.

Why this earns marks: It answers the objective demand and uses monument layering to explain Mauryan legacy without assigning every visible feature to Ashoka.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: Treat “With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin;...” as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For “With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin;...”, add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 06 - 2020 GS-I Q1: Rock-cut architecture and philosophical tradition

Question: Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss with reference to rock-cut architecture. (10 marks, 150 words)

Answer/status: Model answer

Verification: VERIFIED QUESTION from the local official 2020 GS-I paper. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included for Mauryan beginnings and legacy.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Option / dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Mauryan beginning	Barabar Ashokan Ajivika dedications	Ascetic use, imperial patronage and rock technology	Not every Barabar cave has the same dedication
Post-Ashoka bridge	Nagarjuni caves dedicated by Dasharatha	Later-Maurya continuity	Does not prove empirewide continuity
Formal translation	Wood/hut forms rendered in stone	Tradition transformed into durable architecture	Specific prototypes are reconstructed
Later plural growth	Bhaja, Karle, Ajanta, Udayagiri-Khandagiri	Buddhist/Jain/Brahmanical expansion	Dates and patrons vary

Solved analysis

- Indian rock-cut architecture translated ascetic, ritual and congregational needs into durable space. The Mauryan starting point is Barabar, where Ashokan inscriptions dedicate polished caves to Ajivikas; this links imperial patronage, renunciant tradition and new stone technology. Dasharatha's Nagarjuni inscriptions continue Ajivika cave patronage after Ashoka, proving selective dynastic and cultural continuity.
- Later Buddhist chaityas and viharas at Bhaja, Karle and Ajanta developed processional, congregational and monastic forms, while Jain and Brahmanical caves widened the religious field. Facades and interiors often translated wooden architectural vocabulary into rock, but chronology and patronage must be established site by site.
- Thus philosophy and tradition shaped function and symbolism, while craft organisation, royal/merchant patronage and material technology shaped the monuments' realised form.

Why this earns marks: It follows the directive, uses Mauryan and post-Mauryan named evidence, broadens to plural traditions and explains how ideas interacted with patronage and technology.

PYQ discipline: The local official paper controls wording. An unavailable local key is never presented as official.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original solved 10-marker 1 - Dynasty, empire and legacy

Question: Distinguish the end of the Maurya dynasty from the decline of Mauryan imperial integration and the persistence of Mauryan legacy. (150 words)

Demand and thesis: The three processes overlap but operate on different clocks: a lineage ended, territorial coordination weakened unevenly, and selected political-cultural repertoires continued in transformed settings.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Dynasty	Ashoka dies 232 BCE; Brihadratha-Pushyamitra transition c. 187/185 BCE	Separates ruler death from lineage end	Final event is later-tradition based
Empire	Sparse later inscriptions, Bactrian pressure and regional successors	Shows selective loss of integration	No year-by-year map
Continuity	Nagarjuni caves, Sanchi layers, Prakrit-Brahmi and routes	Institutions/culture cross boundary	Continuity was transformed

Model answer

The death of Ashoka in 232 BCE did not end the Maurya dynasty. Later rulers continued, although their chronology is uncertain; Dasharatha's Nagarjuni cave inscriptions are the only secure later-Maurya royal epigraphy. The conventional dynastic end came c. 187/185 BCE, when later accounts place Pushyamitra's overthrow of Brihadratha. Imperial decline was a longer and regional process. Short reigns weakened command, Bactrian Greek pressure affected the north-west, and provincial elites gained room to redirect revenue and loyalty. The exact date of each separation is unknown. Mauryan legacy followed a third clock. Prakrit-Brahmi public epigraphy, routes, political vocabulary and monumental patronage continued selectively. Sanchi's Ashokan brick core was enlarged under Shunga and Satavahana patrons; the Sarnath capital later became India's national emblem. Thus the dynasty ended, integration fragmented, but material and political repertoires persisted through transformation rather than unchanged survival.

Why this earns marks: The answer directly distinguishes three clocks, uses four named evidence units, and qualifies both succession and continuity.

Evidence-density note: This 10-mark answer uses named evidence in proportion to the demand; every major claim includes significance and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Distinguish the end of the Maurya dynasty from the decline of Mauryan imperial integration...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Distinguish the end of the Maurya dynasty from the decline of Mauryan imperial integration...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original solved 10-marker 2 - Inscriptional public communication

Question: Explain why Ashoka's inscriptional programme is central to the long-term significance of Mauryan rule. (150 words)

Demand and thesis: The edicts made a ruler's political ethics, administrative priorities and regional adaptation durably public on an unprecedented geographical scale.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Public corpus	Major/minor rock and pillar edicts	Durable royal communication	Royal intention, not compliance
Regional adaptation	Brahmi, Kharoshthi, Greek and Aramaic	Communication across linguistic zones	Script is not ethnicity
Political ethics	Rock Edicts XII and XIII	Concord, suffering and dhamma-vijaya	Paternal coercion remained
Administrative reach	Rock Edict III officers and tours	Governance made visible	Functions are context-sensitive

Model answer

Ashoka's inscriptions constitute the earliest large, securely datable corpus of royal public communication across the subcontinent. Major and minor rock edicts, pillar edicts and commemorative records placed the ruler's voice on routes, frontiers and sacred landscapes rather than confining it to court ritual. Their regional adaptation was politically significant. Most used Prakrit-Brahmi, while the north-west included Kharoshthi, Greek and Aramaic; this reveals negotiated communication rather than one uniform language policy. Rock Edict XII publicised sectarian restraint, Rock Edict XIII reflected on Kalinga's suffering, and Rock Edict III named field officers and tours. The limitation is equally important: an edict proves command, self-presentation and an attempt to communicate, not universal comprehension or compliance. Its legacy therefore lies in making ethics, administration and royal responsibility durable public arguments. Later inscriptions changed language and genre, but continued epigraphy as a political technology.

Why this earns marks: It answers significance, names four inscriptional units, explains regional adaptation and states the reception limit.

Evidence-density note: This 10-mark answer uses named evidence in proportion to the demand; every major claim includes significance and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Explain why Ashoka's inscriptional programme is central to the long-term significance of...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Explain why Ashoka's inscriptional programme is central to the long-term significance of...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original solved 10-marker 3 - Pacifism theory

Question: Why is Ashoka's pacifism an insufficient explanation for the decline of the Mauryan Empire? (150 words)

Demand and thesis: Ashoka renounced aggressive conquest, not coercive kingship; pacifism can at most be a limited preparedness hypothesis within a later multi-causal crisis.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Retained force	Forest warning in Rock Edict XIII	Deterrence remained	Not troop-strength data
Retained punishment	Pillar Edict IV	Capital punishment persisted	Reform still mattered
Territory	Kalinga retained and separately governed	No strategic withdrawal	Implementation unknown
Nuance	Upinder's preparedness possibility	Long peace may affect army	Direct evidence absent

Model answer

Ashoka's remorse after Kalinga changed the ideology of conquest, but it did not demilitarise the state. Rock Edict XIII warns forest peoples that the king retained power to punish; Pillar Edict IV presupposes capital punishment, and Kalinga remained annexed under special administrative instructions. No evidence states that Ashoka disbanded the army. Upinder Singh allows a narrower possibility: a long reign with only one early campaign may have reduced military preparedness, contributing to later Greek success. Yet this cannot be isolated from short-lived successors, communication costs, provincial agency and Bactrian pressure in the north-west. Pacifism also fails the regional test, since it cannot by itself explain different trajectories in the Ganga core, Kalinga and Deccan. Therefore, dharma was an ethical reorientation of kingship, while imperial decline arose from interacting structural and political shocks.

Why this earns marks: It rejects the false disbandment claim, supplies direct counter-evidence, retains a qualified inference and restores the regional multi-causal model.

Evidence-density note: This 10-mark answer uses named evidence in proportion to the demand; every major claim includes significance and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Why is Ashoka's pacifism an insufficient explanation for the decline of the Mauryan Empire?...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Why is Ashoka's pacifism an insufficient explanation for the decline of the Mauryan Empire?...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original solved 15-marker 1 - Significance across dimensions

Question: Assess the political, economic and cultural significance of Mauryan rule, while indicating the limits of each claim. (250 words)

Demand and thesis: Mauryan rule was a landmark because it combined unprecedented imperial scale, visible governance, connected economic corridors and monumental-inscriptional culture; none of these, however, was territorially uniform or created from nothing.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Political	Pataliputra, provincial centres and Rock Edict VI	Large-scale coordination and reporting	Graded control and communication latency
Economic	Rummindei, punch-marked coins, routes and Sudarshana tradition	Fiscal capacity and exchange	Norms/coins do not measure realised burden or GDP
Epigraphic	Multilingual edicts and Rock Edict XII	Public political ethics	Reception uncertain
Art	Sarnath, Sanchi core and Barabar	Monumental craft and plural patronage	Later phases must be separated
Legacy	Sanchi continuation and national emblem	Long afterlife	Reinterpretation, not unchanged survival

Model answer

Politically, the Mauryas created the first virtually subcontinental empire. Pataliputra, provincial centres at Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri, and Rock Edict VI's reporting ideal reveal unprecedented coordination. Yet edict distribution and southern neighbours show graded, not uniform, control. Economically, Mauryan significance lay in fiscal ambition, regulation and corridor integration. Rummindei records a specific remission of bhaga; punch-marked coins, routes, irrigation traditions and urban infrastructure supported exchange. However, Arthashastra tax lists are normative, coins do not measure GDP, and agrarian-urban processes pre-dated the dynasty. Culturally, Ashoka's multilingual epigraphy made royal ethics public. Rock Edict XII promoted sectarian restraint; Greek, Aramaic, Kharoshthi and Brahmi versions adapted communication regionally. Pillars, the Sarnath capital, Barabar caves and Sanchi's Mauryan core linked court craft with Buddhist and Ajivika patronage. Monument layers and reception must nevertheless be dated separately. Administratively, officers, inspection tours and delegated justice created a visible vocabulary of governance. Rock Edict III's pradeshika, rajuka and yukta and the Kalinga edicts' concern over arbitrary imprisonment show both capacity and the difficulty of controlling agents. These cannot be treated as a modern uniform civil service. The legacy survived selectively: later polities used Prakrit-Brahmi, routes and political vocabulary; Sanchi grew under Shunga and Satavahana patrons, and the Sarnath capital became a national emblem. Mauryan significance therefore lies in scale and repertoire, not in a timeless centralised nation-state.

Why this earns marks: It covers all demanded dimensions, uses more than six named evidence units, and attaches a limitation to every major claim.

Evidence-density note: This 15-mark answer uses named evidence in proportion to the demand; every major claim includes significance and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Assess the political, economic and cultural significance of Mauryan rule, while indicating...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Assess the political, economic and cultural significance of Mauryan rule, while indicating...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original solved 15-marker 2 - Post-Ashoka chronology and regional weakening

Question: Examine the post-Ashoka chronology and the regional pattern of Mauryan weakening. (250 words)

Demand and thesis: After 232 BCE, thin successor evidence and uneven regional detachment replaced Ashoka's empire-wide inscriptional visibility; the conventional final coup ended a dynasty already losing integration.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Chronology	Dasharatha's Nagarjuni inscriptions	Secure later-Maurya anchor	Territory unknown
Lists	Puranic/Buddhist/Jain traditions; Samprati memory	Succession memory	Divergent and late
North-west	Bactrian Greek pressure; c. 206 BCE in Sharma	Frontier acceleration	Regional reach
Centre	Brihadratha-Pushyamitra transition c. 187/185 BCE	Dynastic end	Later account
Regions	Shungas, Kalinga processes and Satavahana emergence	Asynchronous regionalisation	Chronologies debated

Model answer

Ashoka's death in 232 BCE begins a poorly documented later-Maurya phase, not an instantaneous collapse. Dasharatha's Nagarjuni cave inscriptions, dedicated to Ajivikas, are the only secure later-Maurya royal epigraphy. Other successors are known mainly from conflicting Puranic, Buddhist and Jain lists; Samprati, for example, is especially prominent in Jain memory. Weakening was regional. The north-west faced Bactrian Greek pressure, conventionally placed around 206 BCE by R. S. Sharma; this threatened Taxila-Gandhara routes and imperial prestige. In the Ganga-centre, later Mauryas survived until the conventional c. 187/185 BCE Brihadratha-Pushyamitra transition. Central India entered a Shunga-Kanva sequence, while Sanchi continued to expand. Kalinga's later Chetis/Mahameghavahanas and the debated emergence of Satavahana power reflect longer regional state-forming processes, not simultaneous revolts in 232 BCE. The symptoms were equally uneven. The disappearance of an empire-wide Ashokan inscriptional voice indicates reduced public visibility, but not the date of every provincial break. Later Taxila stories preserve conflict with officials, whereas the Kalinga edicts directly show royal anxiety about arbitrary administration. Neither source documents a coordinated all-India rebellion. The pattern therefore combines succession instability, frontier exposure and regional agency. Archaeology and later inscriptions cannot date every provincial separation, but they show that political sovereignty changed while towns, routes, scripts and sacred patronage continued. The final coup terminated the lineage after a longer, uneven loss of imperial integration.

Why this earns marks: It preserves uncertainty, supplies a chronological spine, differentiates four regions and distinguishes final dynastic termination from prior disintegration.

Evidence-density note: This 15-mark answer uses named evidence in proportion to the demand; every major claim includes significance and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Examine the post-Ashoka chronology and the regional pattern of Mauryan weakening. (250...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine the post-Ashoka chronology and the regional pattern of Mauryan weakening. (250...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original solved 15-marker 3 - Brahmanical reaction

Question: Critically examine the theory that a Brahmanical reaction caused the fall of the Mauryan Empire. (250 words)

Demand and thesis: Specific ritual and status tensions are plausible, but the evidence does not support Haraprasad Sastri's empirewide Brahmanical revolution as the principal cause.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Thesis	Sacrifice restrictions and dhamma-mahamattas	Possible ritual/status grievance	Political scale unknown
Counter	Edictal respect for Brahmanas and shramanas	No blanket hostility	Does not erase local tension
Source correction	Upinder rejects Sastri's 'false gods' reading	Weakens textual basis	Other grievances remain possible
Successors	Pushyamitra/Kanvas and Vedic rites	New legitimisation	Successor identity is not cause
Continuity	Dasharatha Ajivika caves; Sanchi expansion	No instant orthodox rupture	Does not prove harmony

Model answer

Haraprasad Sastri interpreted Pushyamitra Shunga's coup as a Brahmanical revolution against Ashoka's heterodox patronage. A limited mechanism is conceivable: restrictions on animal sacrifice may have affected some ritual specialists, and dhamma-mahamattas could be perceived as competing moral authorities. The inscriptional counter-evidence is stronger than the sweeping thesis. Ashoka repeatedly urged respect for Brahmanas and shramanas and patronised a plural religious field. Upinder Singh also shows that Sastri misread the edictal statement about gods and humans mingling as an attack on Brahmanas. Dasharatha's Nagarjuni cave gifts to Ajivikas further complicate claims of an immediate orthodox reversal. Pushyamitra's Brahmana identity and performance of Vedic sacrifices reveal the ideology of a successor court, but do not prove that religious reaction caused earlier losses in the north-west, Kalinga or Deccan. Later Buddhist persecution narratives are sectarian memories requiring archaeological corroboration; continuing construction at Sanchi resists a total-rupture reading. The theory also lacks chronological reach. Succession instability begins after Ashoka, Bactrian Greek pressure operates in the north-west, and provincial assertion follows distinct local opportunities. None of these processes requires a coordinated Brahmanical programme, although religious idioms could help new rulers legitimise power. Thus Brahmanical tension may be retained as a bounded amplifier. Succession shocks, strained integration, regional agency and Bactrian pressure provide a more geographically and chronologically adequate explanation.

Why this earns marks: It states the theory fairly, identifies its possible mechanism, uses inscriptional counter-evidence, source criticism and a graded verdict.

Evidence-density note: This 15-mark answer uses named evidence in proportion to the demand; every major claim includes significance and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **critically examine** requires a direct position on “Critically examine the theory that a Brahmanical reaction caused the fall of the Mauryan...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Critically examine the theory that a Brahmanical reaction caused the fall of the Mauryan...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original solved 20-marker 1 - Major theories of decline

Question: Critically examine the major interpretations of the decline of the Mauryan Empire. Why is a multi-causal explanation more persuasive? (350 words)

Demand and thesis: No single theory fits the chronology, regional pattern and unequal archive; decline is best explained by structural integration costs activated by succession shocks, regional agency and frontier pressure, with weaker fiscal, administrative and ideological amplifiers.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Succession	Short reigns; only Dasharatha inscribed	Strong trigger	Later lists label weakness
Integration	Tours, reports, differentiated edicts and vast geography	Communication/monitoring strain	Real central capacity existed
Fiscal	Army/official costs and Arthashastra fiscal model	Plausible burden	No proven crisis
Provincial	Kalinga justice edicts; Taxila tradition	Abuse and agency	Revolt evidence uneven
Frontier	Bactrian Greek invasion	Strong north-western accelerator	Not all-India cause
Pacifism/reaction	Army/punishment retained; respect for Brahmanas	Rejects monocausal theses	Limited effects possible

Model answer

The post-Ashoka archive is too thin for a single-cause verdict. The first three long reigns were followed by short reigns, and only Dasharatha issued surviving later-Maurya inscriptions. Succession instability therefore plausibly disrupted appointments, military command and dynastic prestige, but 'weak rulers' alone cannot explain regional variation. A structural explanation begins with scale. The empire integrated a metropolitan core, strategic corridors, provinces and frontiers through officials, tours, coercion and ideology. Rock Edicts III and VI reveal supervision and reporting; their very repetition also exposes communication costs. The older overcentralised model is too rigid, because Greek/Aramaic adaptations and regional archaeology show differentiated control. Yet local mediation could itself facilitate detachment when central coordination weakened. R. S. Sharma's fiscal thesis links the large army and officialdom to treasury pressure. Such costs are plausible, but Upinder Singh states that no evidence proves either a state fiscal crisis or a wider economic crisis. Cities, trade, coin use and sacred construction continued. Likewise, Taxila's complaints against wicked officials come from later Buddhist narratives, while the Separate Kalinga Edicts directly prove concern over arbitrary imprisonment, not a coordinated empirewide revolt. External pressure has firmer regional value: Upinder identifies Bactrian Greek invasion as further weakening the empire, especially the north-west. By contrast, the pacifism thesis fails because Ashoka retained the army, capital punishment and forest deterrence; only reduced preparedness remains a modest possibility. Brahmanical-reaction theory is weakened by edictal respect for Brahmanas and Sastri's incorrect reading, although ritual grievance may have existed. Material-diffusion and technological explanations are best treated as background conditions. Iron, bricks, ring wells, routes and state knowledge could strengthen regions once integrated by Magadha, but tools did not mechanically generate successor states. No single ecological shock is established in the consulted evidence. The persuasive model is sequential: vast integration created vulnerability; succession shocks weakened command; regional actors redirected loyalty and revenue; frontier pressure accelerated loss; fiscal, administrative and ideological tensions amplified local crises. The result was uneven disintegration and a final c. 187/185 BCE dynastic coup, not simultaneous civilisational collapse.

Why this earns marks: It tests every major theory, ranks evidence, names inscriptions and traditions, regionalises causation and ends with an explicit interaction model.

Evidence-density note: This 20-mark answer uses named evidence in proportion to the demand; every major claim includes significance and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **critically examine** requires a direct position on "Critically examine the major interpretations of the decline of the Mauryan Empire. Why is a...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Critically examine the major interpretations of the decline of the Mauryan Empire. Why is a...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original solved 20-marker 2 - Significance outliving political fall

Question: 'The Mauryan Empire fell, but Mauryan significance outlived imperial integration.' Evaluate. (350 words)

Demand and thesis: The statement is valid if legacy is understood as selective, transformed repertoires of scale, epigraphy, political ethics, routes and monumental culture rather than unchanged administrative survival.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Scale	Virtually subcontinental empire and provincial corridors	New imperial horizon	Control was graded
Epigraphy	Multilingual Ashokan corpus	Public political communication	Reception unknown
Dhamma	Rock Edicts XII-XIII	Moral foundations and concord	Coercion/hierarchy remained
Material	Pillars, Barabar/Nagarjuni, Sanchi layers	Craft and patronage continuity	Date phases separately
Economy	Urbanisation, trade, money and routes continue	Rejects collapse narrative	Regional variation
Memory	Sarnath national emblem and Ashoka traditions	Long reinterpreted afterlife	Not institutional continuity

Model answer

Mauryan imperial integration was historically finite. After Ashoka, succession became uncertain, north-western pressure intensified, regions detached and the Brihadratha-Pushyamitra transition conventionally ended the dynasty c. 187/185 BCE. Yet political termination did not erase the empire's historical significance. First, the Mauryas established the first virtually subcontinental imperial horizon. Pataliputra, provincial centres and strategic corridors demonstrated a new scale of coordination, even though direct rule remained graded and the far south lay outside the core. Later regional polities operated within routes and state-forming landscapes that Mauryan expansion had intensified. Second, Ashoka created an unprecedented public epigraphic archive. Prakrit-Brahmi inscriptions and north-western Kharoshthi, Greek and Aramaic versions made royal ethics and administration durable across regions. Rock Edict XII placed sectarian concord in political discourse; Rock Edict XIII publicly engaged violence and dhamma-vijaya. These were paternal royal claims, not modern secularism, but they made moral legitimacy a visible problem of kingship. Third, monumental and material legacies crossed the dynastic boundary. The Sarnath capital embodied Mauryan craft and later became India's national emblem. Barabar's Ashokan Ajivika caves were followed by Dasharatha's Nagarjuni dedications. At Sanchi, an Ashokan brick core and pillar were enlarged under Shunga and Satavahana patrons, demonstrating continuity through transformation. Finally, agrarian expansion, towns, trade, money and scripts continued under post-Mauryan polities. Shared titles and Prakrit-Brahmi do not prove unchanged bureaucracy, but they show a transmitted repertoire. Buddhist narratives and modern national symbolism further reinterpreted Ashoka. The limits matter. The Mauryas did not create every town, road, coin or ethical concept, and their empire did not become a modern nation-state. Legacy is strongest where later evidence demonstrates reuse or reinterpretation, and weakest where identical institutions are merely assumed from similar names. Thus the empire's command structure ruptured, while routes, political language, monuments and memories persisted selectively. Its greatest legacy was not a frozen constitution but a set of durable possibilities for empire, public ethics and political representation.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates rather than celebrates, uses more than eight named evidence units and distinguishes political rupture, transformed continuity and later memory.

Evidence-density note: This 20-mark answer uses named evidence in proportion to the demand; every major claim includes significance and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on “The Mauryan Empire fell, but Mauryan significance outlived imperial integration.”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “The Mauryan Empire fell, but Mauryan significance outlived imperial integration.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original solved 20-marker 3 - Overcentralisation and differentiated control

Question: Was overcentralisation responsible for Mauryan decline? Discuss with reference to communication limits, differentiated control and regional agency. (350 words)

Demand and thesis: Overcentralisation is only partly useful: the centre exercised strong strategic functions, but control varied by region and function; the deeper vulnerability was strained integration exposed by succession and regional shocks.

Evidence architecture

Dimension	Named evidence	What it proves	Limitation
Central capacity	Rock Edicts III/VI, provinces, mahamattas and army	Strong appointment/reporting system	Peak evidence is Ashokan
Communication	Periodic tours and constant reports	Distance and monitoring costs	Routes also enabled capacity
Differentiation	Kalinga special edicts, Greek/Aramaic north-west, southern neighbours	Regional adaptation	Not pure autonomy
Agency	Taxila tradition and successor polities	Local actors can detach	Evidence often later
Shock	Short reigns and Bactrian pressure	Activates vulnerability	Relative weights unknown

Model answer

The older image of a highly centralised Mauryan state makes decline appear straightforward: once a weak ruler occupied Pataliputra, a top-heavy bureaucracy collapsed. Evidence does support significant central capacity. Rock Edict VI demands constant reporting; Rock Edict III groups district officers for tours; princes or high governors were associated with major provincial centres; mahamattas, revenue claims and a large army connected court and territory. However, centralisation must be defined by function. Appointment, strategic coercion and imperial ideology may have been relatively centralised, while everyday taxation, production and local justice depended on intermediaries. Communication itself imposed limits: quinquennial tours and repeated injunctions suggest that officials were hard to monitor. The Separate Kalinga Edicts reveal both corrective reach and arbitrary provincial behaviour. Regional evidence further weakens a uniform model. Greek and Aramaic north-western inscriptions were adaptations, not mechanical translations; Kalinga received a special edictal corpus; southern polities were named as neighbours; archaeology in the Deccan does not simply reproduce a northern court package. Such differentiated control reduced the need for uniform bureaucracy but gave local elites resources and legitimacy that could be redirected when the centre faltered. This qualification does not make the empire symbolic. Provincial nodes, routes, waterworks, multilingual communication and deterrence show real capacity. The problem was that this capacity had to be renewed through dynastic authority, inspection and military coordination. Short post-Ashoka reigns weakened those mechanisms, while Bactrian Greek pressure tested the north-west and regional polities emerged elsewhere. Fiscal and ideological factors fit only as amplifiers. Collection may have become harder when provincial loyalty weakened, but no late-Mauryan accounts prove bankruptcy. Dhamma did not abolish army or punishment, while edictal respect for Brahmanas contradicts an empirewide religious revolt. These corrections shift attention back to institutional coordination. Therefore, overcentralisation is an incomplete label. 'Strained integration' is better: a powerful but differentiated imperial network became vulnerable when succession shocks, local agency and frontier pressure overwhelmed its coordinating centre.

Why this earns marks: It defines centralisation by function, balances strong-centre and regional evidence, names inscriptions and ends with a precise replacement concept.

Evidence-density note: This 20-mark answer uses named evidence in proportion to the demand; every major claim includes significance and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Was overcentralisation responsible for Mauryan decline? Discuss with reference to...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Was overcentralisation responsible for Mauryan decline? Discuss with reference to...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.